Military Technology

By 1990 there was no benefit in making faster military aircraft; instead efforts concentrated on updating existing models with the latest technology and materials, to increase their efficiency and range, improve their navigation systems, and upgrade their weapons potential. As fuel consumption became a political issue, more efficient transport aircraft were sought. Only the US had the resources to develop a radical, all-new aircraft: the Stealth Bomber.

△ **Lockheed MC-130P Combat Shadow 1990**

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 4,910 hp Allison T56-A-15 turboprop

Top speed 366 mph (589 km/h)

Aircraft based on the Hercules have supported US Special Operations forces since the 1960s. The MC-130P provides operation command and support, as well as helicopter inflight refueling.

△ **Hawker Siddeley Buccaneer S2 1991**

Origin UK

Engine 2 x 11,100 lb (5,035 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Spey 101 turbofan

Top speed 690 mph (1,110 km/h)

Designed by Blackburn in the 1950s the nuclear strike-capable Buccaneer was the first Royal Navy aircraft to cross the Atlantic without refueling. In 1991 it provided guided bombing in the Gulf War.

△ **Saab JAS 39 Gripen 1990**

Origin Sweden

Engine 12,100–18,100 lb (5,488–8,210 kg) thrust Volvo Aero RM12 afterburning turbofan

Top speed 1,372 mph (2,208 km/h)

This lightweight Mach 2 multirole fighter came with "relaxed stability" delta wings and canards, plus fly-by-wire technology and STOL capability. By 2012, 240 had been delivered to air forces worldwide.

△ **Northrop Grumman B-2 Spirit 1990**

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 17,300 lb (7,847 kg) thrust General Electric F118-GE110 turbofan

Top speed 630 mph (1,010 km/h)

Just 21 flying-wing "Stealth Bombers" were built, costing over $2 billion each. They were able to slip undetected to the heart of enemy territory, and drop 80+ tons of bombs or 17+ tons of nuclear warheads.

△ **British Aerospace Harrier II GR7 1990**

Origin UK

Engine 21,750 lb (9,866 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Pegasus 105 vectored-thrust turbofan

Top speed 662 mph (1,065 km/h)

Unique in its V/STOL (vertical or short takeoff and landing) capability, the Harrier was completely revised in the 1980s with composite fuselage, more power, and improved avionics.

▽ **Dassault Mirage 2000D 1991**

Origin France

Engine 14,300–21,400 lb (6,486–9,707 kg) thrust SNECMA M53-P2 afterburning turbofan

Top speed 1,453 mph (2,338 km/h)

France's nuclear strike Mirage 2000N was developed into the 2000D for long-range strikes with conventional weapons, being equipped with improved controls, navigation, and defenses.